a last-ditch bid to stall Ratan's appointment as chairman. He called on Moolgaokar to try and pacify him and persuade him to change his mind.

But Mody's attempt at disarming the ailing TELCO chief failed abjectly as the latter's hurt had run deep. It was a classic case of too little too late, perhaps. Everything was over in just five minutes.

As Moolgaokar had already resigned, Ratan chaired the board meeting, now more as a matter of right than when he had deputed for the ailing TELCO veteran. JRD, however, was not to be seen anywhere. He came in about half an hour after the meeting had started.

At the meeting, he turned to Palkhivala, who had drafted Moolgaokar's resignation letter, and said that there were several obstacles to accepting the proposal of TELCO's outgoing chief to make Ratan the chairman. Palkhivala replied that the deck was clear for handing over the baton to Ratan. JRD then said, 'By the way, you can't do it without the consent of the lenders.'

To his surprise, Suresh Shankar Nadkarni, who later became chairman, Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI), and was present at the meeting as the director representing IDBI, replied that the lenders had already given their permission the previous day. There was 'dead silence', recalls Ratan. It was only broken when Nadkarni rose to his feet and said, 'I welcome the new chairman.' And that was the end of the saga.

After he was appointed chairman, TELCO, Ratan left for Jamshedpur. Mody surprised him by having a special messenger with a letter waiting for him at the airport. It was a warm congratulatory note, along with an invitation to breakfast at his house.

In the handwritten letter, Mody conveyed that he would support the young Tata and would always be there for him. He wrote: 'Should you need it, my help is always there and you can count on it.' Beginning the letter with 'My dear Ratan', he closed it with 'Love, Russi' to convey his professed affection for the young Tata.

At breakfast, the conversation veered around to TELCO and Mody sprang a surprise on his guest. He requested Ratan to appoint him as the executive vice chairman. A surprised Ratan quickly gathered his wits around him and asked him why Mody wanted a formal appointment when they could 'work together'.

Mody insisted. Ratan hastened to end the signs of an emerging dust-up at breakfast by suggesting that they could have a 'debate' on this issue along